

Opening Line Cards

Pick two forms and drill them for two weeks, on everything, including trivial messages. Write the line last, place it first.

The direct form

"This matters because..." Works almost everywhere. The default.

The executive form

"The decision this enables is..." Strongest for senior readers, who are deciding whether to keep reading.

The document form

"By the end of this you'll know..." Best for documents and presentations.

The request form

"We're doing this so that..." Best for instructions and asks, it carries the reason with the work.

The FYI form

"Nothing needed from you; this is so that..." Prevents mis-escalation and needless replies.

The fifteen-second rule

After the content exists, the purpose line takes fifteen seconds. Written before, it takes real energy. Write it last, place it first.